

Listening Exercises

The loop, the three enemies, "listening or ideas?", a 10-minute practice session, prompts and reflection · Module 6, Training 1

The loop (Carl Rogers)

Attention (face them, phone away, eyes mostly on theirs) → **Reflect** (say back what you heard, your words, nothing added) → **Check** ("Did I get that right?") → **Go deeper** (one open question: "What was the hardest moment?") → Reflect again.

Active listening left people feeling more understood and more satisfied than receiving advice (Weger et al., *International Journal of Listening*); perceived partner responsiveness predicts relationship quality and health (Reis et al.).

The three enemies

ENEMY	SOUNDS LIKE	REPLACE WITH
Fixing	"Have you tried the breathing?"	"So you're scared, and it's sitting in your chest."
Defending	"I had a meeting, what was I supposed to do?"	"You felt alone at the clinic."
Matching	"You think <i>you're</i> exhausted?"	"You're completely worn out."

The most useful sentence in this module: *"Listening or ideas?"* Let them choose. In the first ten minutes, most people choose listening.

Questions that go deeper (not sideways)

Open, curious, one at a time: "What was the hardest moment?" · "What are you most afraid it means?" · "What would help?" · "What else have you been picturing?" Avoid "why" (puts people on trial) and "did you..." (leads where you've already decided).

The 10-minute practice session (40 XP)

Phones in another room. A timer. Sit facing each other.

MINUTES	WHO	WHAT
0–4	Partner A speaks; Partner B only reflects, checks and asks one open question	Prompt (choose one below)
4–5	Swap seats, breathe	
5–9	Partner B speaks; Partner A listens the same way	Prompt
9–10	Each: one sentence on how it felt to be listened to without being fixed	

Prompts - Something about this journey I haven't said out loud. - A fear I carry about the next few months. - A dream: a moment I've been picturing. - What the last appointment / test / conversation was really like for me. - Something I need more of from you, said gently. - What I'm proudest of from the last six weeks.

Solo version: do the session by phone or on a walk with a friend, sibling or your accountability partner. Ask them to reflect rather than advise; send them this page.

Reflection (30 XP)

Being listened to without being fixed felt:

The enemy I reached for most (fixing / defending / matching):

One thing I learned about my partner (or my friend):

One thing I learned about myself as a listener:

Share in the forum (20 XP)

Post one sentence: what listening did, or what made it hard.

Educational content only, not medical advice. Always consult your doctor or a qualified health professional before changing supplements, diet, exercise or detox practices, especially while trying to conceive.